

Demise of the monoculture

TREND 1 | US South

Abstract

There has been a lot written about the shattering of the consensus reality. That plays out in myriad ways, but a critical part is the social and cultural atomization created. In a culture where a shared understanding of reality is absent as the load-bearing pillar of a monoculture, there is a tangible real-world loss of community and disconnection from a true popular culture; Subcultures have filled this gap.

The constellation of media spaces, both social, alt, and traditional, have become so plentiful and so catered that individuals can find and connect with incredibly niche subcultures. Subcultures have always existed for people seeking a community that resonates more with their interests and values, but those spaces have been divergent aberrations from monoculture. Subcultures are now the default spaces.

Localized incarnations

Niche cultural events

In any large metro there has been an explosion in hyper-niche community and cultural events. What was once, more or less, one art scene is now a vast constellation of art directed at very specific audiences. It was once easy to be plugged into almost all art and cultural events and spaces.

Obscured entry points

Hobbies and special interest have also exploded as individuals feel the hole left by the absence of community. On any given weekend, there are innumerable hobby meetups that are completely inaccessible to those outside of an established community.

Death of the gatekeeper

Niche spaces that were once zealously guarded by the zealots of the subculture eager to maintain the intentional distance from the monoculture applied social pressure to keep out those seen as interlopers. With the dissolution of the monoculture and its replacement with subcultures as the default norm, this social pressure mechanism has reversed; gatekeepers are social pariahs.

Business and design implications

Niche targeting

Reaching broad swaths of the population is now incredibly difficult, products and services that attempt to are largely regarded with contempt as being out of touch or normie. Communications strategies of the future will have to learn how to gain entry to niche spaces and find messaging that can resonate with subsets or groupings of subsets of the broader population. Savvy, effective communicators will be able authentically gain access to these niche communities.

Design for narrower swaths of tastes

Gone are the days of sleek, minimalist, baohaus design aesthetics and methodologies which embrace a “correct” way to design. Niche communities have niche tastes and ultraspecialized psychologies and philosophies. To the extent it was ever true, there are no universal laws of usability and desirability anymore.